

From Empire to Enlightenment

1500-1800

The expansion of empires in the 16th century transformed the world. Trade routes developed, distant islands were connected by ships, and power shifted. Such changes challenged traditional values, and women's lives were increasingly bound up with the political and military battles of the time. Many women became powerful or influential figures. However, for every woman driving change, there were dozens more fighting for their basic rights in the newly forming classes of society. Local cultures and practices were constantly under threat, and many changes had a negative impact on women, imposing strict limitations on their lives.